# 📬 From Doc's Mailbox: VOLATILITY > Shift vs Slide — What's the Difference?

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DOC MCGRAW
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📬 From Doc's Mailbox: Shift vs Slide — What's the Difference?

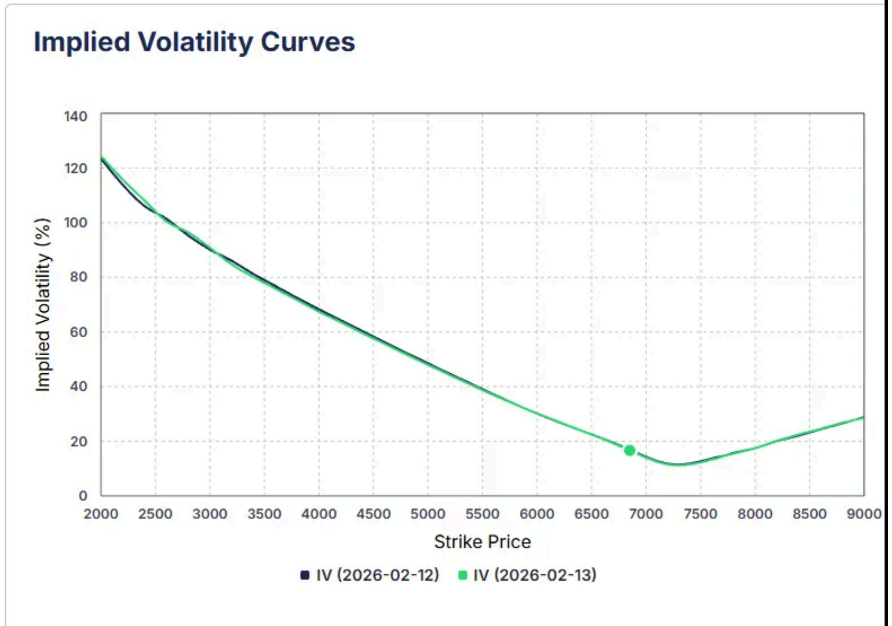
Got a good question this weekend from a subscriber:

"Doc, anyone happen to know what shift/slide refers to in regards to option vol? I keep seeing it mentioned but nobody explains it in plain English."

Fair point. This stuff gets thrown around like everyone should just know. Let me walk through it using Friday's VIX Decomposition as a live example—because this isn't just theory. It's what actually happened.

12 February 2026 | 13 February 2026 | Compute

| | S&P 500 | VIX |
|---|---|---|
| 2026-02-12 | 6832.76 | 20.82 |
| 2026-02-13 | 6836.17 | 20.60 |
| Day Change (Abs) | 3.41 | (0.22) |
| Day Change (Pct) | 0.05% | (1.06)% |
| **VIX Decomposition Factors** | | |
| STICKY STRIKE | | 0.09 |
| PARALLEL SHIFT | | (0.24) |
| PUT SKEW | | 0.17 |
| CALL SKEW | | (0.13) |
| DOWNSIDE CONVEXITY | | (0.10) |
| UPSIDE CONVEXITY | | (0.01) |
| **Total of VIX Decomposition Factors** | | **(0.22)** |




## The Setup

Friday, SPX climbed about 3.4 points. VIX dropped 0.22. Simple enough, right? Market up, vol down. Tale as old as time.

But why did VIX drop? The decomposition table breaks it into pieces—and two of those pieces are "Sticky Strike" and "Parallel Shift." That's the shift vs slide debate in real numbers.

📍 The "Shift" (Sticky Strike)

Think of burger joints lined up on a street.

Joe's Diner sells a burger for $8. The hipster place three doors down charges $12. The fancy steakhouse at the end of the block wants $18. Those prices are on the menu. Taped to the window. Fixed.

You're standing in front of Joe's. $8 burger. Life is good.

Now you walk three doors down. You didn't ask anyone to change anything. You just moved. But now you're standing in front of a different menu. $12. That's what it costs here.

That's Sticky Strike. Each strike on the options chain has its IV posted. The 6800 put has its price. The 6850 put has its price. The 6900 put has its price. They're on the menu. The menu doesn't care where SPX is trading.

Friday, the market walked you down the street. SPX moved 3.4 points higher. You didn't change what any individual strike was charging for vol. You just ended up standing in front of a different window.

That mechanical repositioning alone? Pushed VIX up by 0.09.

Nobody changed their mind about volatility. Nobody panicked. Nobody got greedy. The market just moved, and you're reading a different menu now. Cost of doing business. The "shift."

## 🛝 The "Slide" (Sticky Delta / Sticky Moneyness)

Now imagine something different happens.

You're still standing in front of Joe's Diner. You didn't walk anywhere. But overnight, the cost of beef dropped 15%. Wholesale meat prices collapsed.

What happens the next morning? Joe's drops the burger from $8 to $7. The hipster place goes from $12 to $10. The steakhouse cuts from $18 to $15. Every single menu on the street reprices—together, in the same direction, by roughly the same amount.

You didn't move. But your burger got cheaper because the input cost changed for everyone.

That's the "slide." That's what traders mean when they say "sliding down the skew."

In vol terms: the market rallied Friday. Fear subsided. The underlying input—the demand for protection—dropped. So the whole menu of IV prices across all strikes dropped together. The curve didn't stay fixed. It floated lower with the price action.

That's PARALLEL SHIFT in the table: -0.24. Negative. The entire street got cheaper. Every strike's IV came down a bit because the "cost of fear" declined with the rally.

## 🎯 So What Actually Happened Friday?

VIX dropped 0.22 on the day. Now you know the tug-of-war:

Sticky Strike wanted VIX higher (+0.09) "You walked to a pricier diner. The menu there costs more."

Parallel Shift wanted VIX lower (-0.24) "But meat prices dropped and everyone cut their menu."

Slide won. The whole street repriced cheaper. The curve moved with the market. That's the regime we were in Friday.

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## 🧠 Why Does This Matter?

Because it tells you what's driving vol—and what to expect next.

If VIX is moving mostly because of Sticky Strike effects, the surface itself isn't really changing. You're just walking past different menus. The fear isn't going anywhere. It's mechanical, not emotional.

If VIX is moving mostly because of Parallel Shift, the whole market is repricing fear. That's a regime signal. When the slide dominates, rallies tend to compress vol and selloffs tend to expand it—reflexively.

Friday's decomp showed the slide in control. Fear came out. The whole skew dropped. That's consistent with the "exhausted fear bid" thesis we've been watching.

### ⚡ The Bottom Line

When you hear shift vs slide, just ask yourself:

Shift: Did I walk to a different menu? Slide: Did the whole street reprice together?

The VIX decomposition shows you which one is running the show in real time. And right now? The slide is winning. Fear is bleeding out, not building.

Gotta WATCH the FLOW to be in the KNOW. 🐐

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